



AA LEGAL

...Committed to excellence!!!



Business Operations

A Comprehensive Overview

An end-to-end account of how AA Legal serves its clients — from the first enquiry to file closure — across family law, real estate, criminal law, immigration, and wills & estates.



FIRM

AA Legal — Calgary, Alberta

PRINCIPAL

Yemi Ayorinde, B/S/NP

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Business Operations Manual

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Who We Are & What We Stand For



AA Legal is a Calgary-based law firm founded on three enduring pillars: **professionalism, integrity, and compassion**. We serve individuals, families, and businesses across Alberta with a full suite of legal services delivered with the warmth of a community practice and the rigor of a corporate firm.

Our Mission

To provide accessible, ethical, and outcome-driven legal services that protect our clients' rights, assets, and futures — at every life stage and through every transaction.

Our Vision

To be Alberta's most trusted boutique law firm — recognised for excellence in client care, technological sophistication, and meaningful community contribution.

Our Core Values

- ✓ Professionalism in every interaction
- ✓ Integrity above expediency
- ✓ Compassion for clients' circumstances
- ✓ Confidentiality & privilege protection
- ✓ Continuous learning & modernisation
- ✓ Community service & pro-bono work

"Our work is, at its heart, the work of helping people through the most consequential moments of their lives. We strive to do that work with skill, with honour, and with heart."

Areas of Practice

Each practice area is supported by structured intake, dedicated workflows, precedent libraries, and clear fee structures — ensuring consistent quality regardless of who you meet at AA Legal.

PRACTICE · I

Family Law

Divorce & separation, child custody & parenting plans, child & spousal support, division of matrimonial property, prenuptial & cohabitation agreements, adoption, and protection orders.

PRACTICE · II

Real Estate

Residential & commercial purchases and sales, refinancing, title transfers, mortgage instructions, condominium document review, builder transactions, and independent legal advice.

PRACTICE · III

Criminal Law

Bail hearings, impaired driving, assault, theft & fraud, drug offences, summary & indictable trials, sentencing submissions, appeals, and record suspensions.

PRACTICE · IV

Immigration

Express Entry, Provincial Nominee Programs, family sponsorship, work & study permits, citizenship applications, refugee claims, LMIA support, and appeals.

PRACTICE · V

Wills & Estates

Wills, enduring powers of attorney, personal directives, trusts, probate & administration, estate litigation, succession planning, and notarisations.

ADDITIONAL

Notarial Services

Affidavits, statutory declarations, commissioning of oaths, certified true copies, travel consents, and notarised translations.

Twelve Stages of a Client Matter

Every file at AA Legal flows through a disciplined twelve-stage process. The framework is designed to meet Law Society of Alberta standards, ensure consistent quality, and protect both the client and the firm.

I

Initial Enquiry & Lead Capture

Prospective clients reach us by phone, email, website form, referral, or walk-in. Every enquiry is logged in the CRM with source, matter type, and urgency.

- ◆ Multi-channel intake: phone, email, web, referral
- ◆ Same-day acknowledgement target
- ◆ Triage to the appropriate practice area

II

Conflict Check & KYC

Before any substantive discussion, a conflict-of-interest search is run, and client identification is completed under the Law Society's Client Identification and Verification Rules.

- ◆ Name, address, occupation, and ID verification
- ◆ Source-of-funds enquiry where applicable
- ◆ Politically Exposed Person (PEP) screening

III

Consultation & Scope Definition

An in-person, telephone, or video consultation explores the client's objectives, risks, and possible strategies. The client receives a candid assessment of merits, costs, and timelines.

- ◆ 30–60 minute consultation (free or flat-fee)
- ◆ Issue spotting and preliminary strategy
- ◆ Discussion of fees, billing, and expectations

IV

Retainer & Engagement Letter

A written retainer agreement defines scope, fee structure (hourly, flat, contingency, block), trust deposit, billing cycle, and the rights and duties of both parties.

- ◆ E-signed retainer via DocuSign or Adobe Sign
- ◆ Trust deposit collected via Interac, cheque, or wire
- ◆ Trust ledger opened per LSA trust accounting rules

V

File Opening & Matter Setup

A new matter is created in the practice management system with a unique file number, deadlines calendared, document folder created, and the responsible lawyer and paralegal assigned.

- ◆ Matter plan and task list
- ◆ Limitation and court deadlines diarised
- ◆ Document templates pre-loaded

VI

Discovery, Research & Document Collection

The firm gathers evidence, financial disclosure, contracts, identification, or whatever the file requires; conducts legal research; and prepares a working file plan.

- ◆ Secure client portal for document upload
- ◆ Statutory and case-law research (CanLII, Westlaw, Lexis)
- ◆ Witness interviews where applicable

VII

Strategy & Drafting

The lawyer drafts pleadings, contracts, wills, agreements, demand letters, or immigration applications. All drafts undergo internal review before being sent to the client.

- ◆ Precedent library and clause bank
- ◆ Two-stage internal review
- ◆ Plain-language client summaries

VIII

Negotiation & Representation

The firm represents the client before opposing counsel, government agencies (IRCC, Land Titles), tribunals, or courts — pursuing settlement first where appropriate.

- ◆ Mediation and collaborative practice
- ◆ Court appearances and hearings
- ◆ Regular client status updates

IX

Execution & Closing

Documents are signed, registered, filed, or submitted. Funds are disbursed from trust. Title transfers, divorce judgments, probate grants, or PR confirmations are obtained.

- ◆ E-signing and remote commissioning
- ◆ Trust disbursement with full reconciliation
- ◆ Registration with Land Titles, courts, or IRCC

X

Billing & Collections

Time entries are captured daily; invoices are issued per the retainer schedule; trust funds are applied per LSA rules; outstanding receivables are followed up systematically.

- ◆ Detailed dockets and transparent narratives
- ◆ Electronic invoicing and online payment
- ◆ Monthly trust reconciliation

XI

File Closing & Reporting Letter

Upon completion the firm issues a reporting letter summarising the work done, outcomes, and any ongoing client obligations such as updating a will after major life events.

- ◆ Final reporting letter
- ◆ Return of original documents
- ◆ Closed-file archiving (10+ years per LSA rules)

XII

Post-Engagement & Client Retention

The firm requests feedback, invites reviews, schedules periodic check-ins (estate refresh, immigration renewal), and continues to add value via newsletters and seminars.

- ◆ NPS survey and testimonials
- ◆ Annual "legal check-up" reminders
- ◆ Referrals and alumni program

Functional Departments Behind the Practice



Behind every file is a coordinated set of operational functions that keep AA Legal compliant, profitable, and client-centric.

Client Services

- Reception & phone handling
- Appointment scheduling
- Walk-in greeting & intake forms
- Client portal access & support
- Multi-language coordination

Legal Practice

- Lawyer file ownership
- Paralegal & clerk support
- Drafting & document review
- Court & tribunal appearances
- Continuing professional development

Compliance & Risk

- LSA Code of Conduct adherence
- Conflict checks & KYC
- Anti-money-laundering (FINTRAC)
- Insurance & ALIA reporting
- File audit & quality assurance

Trust & Accounting

- Trust ledger management
- General ledger & bookkeeping
- Monthly bank reconciliation
- Annual LSA trust report
- Payroll & HST/GST filings

Technology & Security

- Practice management system
- Cloud backup & encryption
- Cybersecurity & phishing defence
- E-signing & document automation
- Website & client portal

Marketing & Business Development

- Website & SEO
- Google Business Profile & reviews
- Social media & newsletters
- Referral relationships
- Community sponsorships & seminars

Human Resources

- Recruitment & onboarding
- Articling student supervision
- Performance reviews
- Policy & handbook maintenance
- Office & vendor management

Knowledge Management

- Precedent & clause libraries
- Internal know-how database
- Practice notes & checklists
- CPD records
- Client FAQs & guides

The AA Legal Client Journey



A simplified view of the path every client travels with the firm — from first contact to a long-term advisory relationship.



"The brief we are given today by a client may be only the first chapter — our intent is to remain their trusted counsel for every chapter that follows."

Key Performance Indicators



The metrics we monitor monthly to ensure the practice runs to a high standard.

< 4h

FIRST RESPONSE

≥ 95%

CONFLICT
COVERAGE

100%

TRUST
RECONCILED

≥ 4.8★

CLIENT RATING

≥ 70%

LAWYER
UTILISATION

< 30d

INVOICE AGING

0

MISSED
DEADLINES

≥ 40%

REPEAT &
REFERRAL

Regulatory & Compliance Framework

AA Legal operates within a strict regulatory ecosystem. Compliance is built into every workflow.

REGULATOR / AUTHORITY	SCOPE	AA LEGAL OBLIGATION
Law Society of Alberta (LSA)	Professional conduct, trust accounting	Annual reports, CPD, trust audits, Code of Conduct
Alberta Lawyers Insurance Association	Professional liability insurance	Active coverage, incident reporting
FINTRAC	Anti-money-laundering	Client ID, large cash & suspicious transaction reports
Privacy Commissioner (PIPA/ PIPEDA)	Client data protection	Privacy policy, breach reporting, secure storage
Canada Revenue Agency	Taxation	GST/HST filings, T4/T5018, corporate tax
Court of King's Bench / Provincial Court	Litigation procedure	Filing rules, court dress, deadlines
IRCC	Immigration matters	Authorised representative status, approved forms
Land Titles Office (Alberta)	Real-estate registration	Electronic registration credentials, fee schedules

Tools That Power the Practice



A modern stack underpins every department — chosen for security, compliance, and Canadian residency where possible.

Practice Management

- Clio / PCLaw / CosmoLex
- Matter, time & trust in one system
- Court-rules engine for deadlines

Document & Knowledge

- NetDocuments / iManage
- Microsoft 365 with Canadian tenancy
- Precedent & clause libraries

Communication

- Encrypted email (TLS, S/MIME)
- Secure client portal
- Zoom / Teams for virtual meetings

E-Signing & ID

- DocuSign / Adobe Sign
- Persona / Onfido for KYC
- Remote commissioning where permitted

Research

- CanLII, Westlaw Edge, Lexis+ Canada
- Practical Law
- Internal knowledge base

Accounting & Payments

- QuickBooks / Xero integration
- LawPay / Clio Payments
- Interac e-Transfer, EFT, wire

Security

- MFA on all systems
- Endpoint encryption & MDM
- Daily encrypted backups (Canadian region)

Marketing

- WordPress / website CMS
- Google Business Profile
- Mailchimp newsletters

How We Protect Clients & the Firm



Confidentiality & Privilege

- ✓ Solicitor-client privilege protected by safeguards
- ✓ Need-to-know access controls
- ✓ Confidential shredding & secure disposal
- ✓ NDAs with vendors handling client data

Risk Management

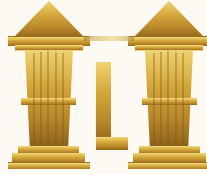
- ✓ Diarised limitation & deadline calendar
- ✓ Mandatory peer review on high-stakes drafts
- ✓ Cyber-incident response plan
- ✓ Annual compliance & ethics training

"A reputation for ethics is built one careful decision at a time. We do not trade integrity for expediency — not on any file, not on any day."

How AA Legal Earns & Bills

Fee structures are matched to the matter type and the client's needs — always transparent, always disclosed in the retainer.

FEE MODEL	TYPICAL USE	CLIENT BENEFIT
Flat / Block Fee	Wills, real-estate closings, notarisations, simple immigration applications	Cost certainty
Hourly	Family litigation, complex estates, commercial disputes	Pay for actual effort
Retainer Replenishment	Ongoing litigation matters	Predictable cash flow
Limited-Scope (Unbundled)	Coaching self-reps, document review	Affordable, targeted help
Contingency	Select civil matters (where permitted)	No win, no fee
Pro Bono / Reduced Fee	Community service files	Access to justice



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TELEPHONE

+1 (825) 558-1337

FACSIMILE

403-457-4707

WEB

www.aalegal.ca

EMAIL

yemi.a@aalegal.ca

OFFICE

Suite 115, 1925 – 18th Avenue NE, Calgary AB T2E 7T8

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